Balancing or hedging?

India is gradually aligning itself with the United States, but it still has a distance to go before their cooperation resembles anything close to a military alliance. India has not signed any formal alliance agreement with the United States, and its defence cooperation with the United States is not at a level where it signals a strong will for joint efforts vis-à-vis China. Short of a “military alliance,” judging whether India is hard balancing or hedging against China’s rise largely rests on India’s internal defence policy measures. In a bipolar international order, with the United States and China as the two poles, India is a secondary power. Secondary powers are usually not able to be a counterweight and balance great powers by themselves. Nonetheless, India is no ordinary secondary power; it is arguably the strongest secondary power and the one with the largest long-term potential to balance China. Still, hard balancing, in the narrow sense of the concept, requires India to be a counterweight to China, to engage China in an intense rivalry, and to seriously attempt to close the gap in capabilities. India is undertaking various balancing efforts, like purchasing and building key weapon platforms, and moving specialised troops to the border regions, as discussed by Kalyanaraman and Engh in their chapters, but we do not find India’s current internal balancing efforts substantial enough to classify them as proof of hard balancing. India is certainly building deterrence that includes nuclear weapons and a solid presence on the border, but deterrence is not necessarily the same as balancing, and, as noted by Waltz, nuclear weapons are just one of many indicators influencing the distribution of power between states.[6]

India’s policy vis-à-vis China today resembles that of China’s towards the United States from the mid-1990s